A. N. Afanasyev — Poetic Views of the Slavs on Nature (1865–69)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

For Alexander Nikolaevich Afanasyev (1826–1871), who gathered the tales of a people and built the great house of their meaning — and died before the world would read it in any tongue but his own. The tale-collector has had his English shelf for a hundred years; the thinker who explained the tales has stood outside the door.

The author's own terms

The world-tree, or tree of life: in Afanasyev's own sense, the rain-cloud pictured as a giant tree embracing the whole world — branches turned downward to earth, roots reaching to the highest heaven, its living water the rain and dew; a poetic image with a weather referent, not a decorative myth. Leshy (plural leshie; also lesovik): the forest spirit who governs the forest and its beasts. Afanasyev gives no one-line definition of the leshy, and none is imposed here.

The story

Born at Boguchar on 23 July 1826 — the birthplace and exact dates rest on the external reference record; the folder pins only the years — he studied law at

Moscow University, graduating in 1848, and held a post in the Main Archive of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. In 1862 he was found passing archive documents for publication abroad, and lost the post. His last years were spent in poverty; he died at Moscow on 5 October 1871, aged forty-five, of tuberculosis.

Collector and scholar are the same man: he gathered and published nearly six hundred Russian folk tales — a Russian counterpart to the Brothers Grimm — and on that treasury built *Poetic Views*, three volumes, Moscow: K. Soldatenkov, 1865, 1868, and 1869.

The work and what survives

Its full subtitle, as the 2024 survey gives it, is *An Attempt at a Comparative Study of Slavic Traditions and Beliefs in Connection with the Mythical Tales of Other Related Peoples*. It reads Slavic tale, song, spell, riddle, and custom as the broken remains of one old poetic vision of the world, compared throughout with the other Indo-European peoples — at its heart, light against dark, spring life against winter deadness. A nineteenth-century system, it must be read as one: some etymologies belong to its age, and the survey notes that some cited materials are unreliable, while treating the book as a founding monument of Slavic mythology studies.

Chapter XVII, “The Tree of Life and Forest Spirits” — the seventeenth of twenty-eight chapters, Volume 2 (1868), printed pages 277–349 — moves in two parts: the world-tree (pages 277–325), traced through Indian, Persian, Scandinavian, Greek, German, and Slavic tradition and the Slavs' sacred trees (ash, oak of Perun, aspen, golden apples, nut), and from page 326 the forest and its spirits, the leshie among giants, dwarfs, lisunki, and divozheny.

The folder holds XVII complete in draft, translated fresh from the Russian — 18,628 Russian words per the folder's record — nothing silently abridged. Its scope is one chapter: the other twenty-seven remain untranslated in the folder.

Its English fortunes

No complete English translation of *Poetic Views* was found after research; passages are quoted in English inside modern scholarship, including the

2024 *Religions* survey the folder cites.

The survey's unqualified sentence — that the book “has never been translated into English” — fails at passage level: the survey itself prints Englished quotations from the work. Quotation is not a translation of the book; this dossier claims no more than the bold finding above and does not call itself a first of anything.

The bound must be kept clean: the folk *Tales* have been in English for a century, Englished repeatedly in selections, a Pantheon Books edition among them. Nothing here implies the *Tales* waited with the masterwork; the gap belongs to the masterwork only.

What completing it would take

Chapter XVII needs verification, not further translation: collation against the two scans the folder names — the Google Books scan held by Wikimedia Commons and the independent Internet Archive scan — and the fact-audit its headnote describes, with its scholarly caution kept beside the dedication's honour.

Completing the work entire would take the remaining twenty-seven chapters, each given a word-count and page-map from the scans before any chapter is promised, as was done for XVII. Any next chapter is a fresh editorial ruling, not momentum.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/afanasyev-poetic-views-ch17/afanasyev-poetic-views-ch17.txt`
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-afanasyev.md`
- “Afanas'ev's *Poetic Views of the Slavs' on Nature* and Its Role in Understanding Paganism and Mythology,” *Religions* 15(2): 206 (2024): https://www.mdpi.com/2077-1444/15/2/206 — DOI 10.3390/rel15020206
- Biographical record (external to the folder): https://en.wikipedia.org/

wiki/Alexander_Afanasyev

- English *Russian Fairy Tales* (Pantheon Books edition, a different work), Internet Archive: https://archive.org/details/russianfairytale00afan/russianfairytale00afan